Back in Agra, Akbar was beginning to realize the great disadvantage of this franchise model of empire-building: his commanders might be expanding his frontiers, but his treasury was empty. Bayazid, an old soldier of Humayun's, tells the famous story of Akbar's treasurer unable to find seventeen rupees for the padishah.[11] Maham, who eventually gave Akbar the money from her own purse, is sometimes accused of running a corrupt government that led to this pitiful state of affairs. It's also said that Munim Khan, who couldn't force Akbar to school, was far too placatory of the Mughal commanders – some of whom, including Ali Quli Shaibani, were none too happy with Bairam's abrupt removal – and allowed a 'slackening' in their remittances.[12] In fact, at about the same time as Adham's victory in Malwa, Ali Quli had won a great battle, too, but not a copper coin of his loot – or even an elephant – had reached Akbar's court.

The padishah had had enough. With the same burst of temper that sent him galloping on his fiery Hayran, years ago, Akbar went racing from Agra to Sarangpur.

He left in relative secret, 'without informing the great officers and Eyes of the State'. Munim Khan knew, writes Abul Fazl, but he says nothing about Maham Anaka.

If Akbar didn't tell her, believing that she might make excuses for her son, Maham found out. She sent 'swift couriers' to warn Adham, but Akbar was far swifter. He made it from Agra to Sarangpur, over 500-odd kilometres of 'ascents and descents', in just over two weeks.[13]

This wasn't the last time that Akbar's sheer speed befuddled his foe. On 13 May 1561, Adham Khan was riding out of Sarangpur, in all tranquillity.[14] As he rode on, however, Adham noticed the soldiers ahead of him behaving oddly. Peering into the distance, he saw them getting off their horses and throwing themselves to the ground. 'Good God,' wondered Adham Khan, 'to whom are they paying such reverence?'[15] Spurring his horse forward, he was amazed to find Akbar the cause of his army's mid-march prostrations. Adham Khan got off his horse and kissed Akbar's saddle in deference. Akbar, too, dismounted, as a way of reassuring Maham's son. The two men rode back to Sarangpur in apparent amity.

The good feeling didn't last. Back in the palace, Adham made a belated presentation of 'things rare and beautiful', but to little effect. Whether